University of Otago
ŌTĀKOU WHAKAIHU WAKA

Department of Accountancy and Finance

2026 (June) PhD Symposium

Semester 1, 2026

This page has been intentionally left blank.

Background

The PhD workshop/symposium is designed by Professor Jin Zhang for all postgraduate students in the Department of Accountancy and Finance at the University of Otago to present their research progress, offer comments and support each other. This is a semi-annually departmental event, which has run since 2015.

The symposium aims to stimulate our research progress and communication. It is a perfect time for postgraduate students to know each other's research interests. All PhD/MCom students are required to attend the symposium. Every presenter is assigned approximately 6 minutes (5 minutes presentation plus 1 minute Q&A) for their presentation. The order of the presentations will be based on PhD/MCom seniority. Those who joined our department earlier will present first.

In June 2024, awards for Outstanding Research Contribution, Presentation, and Impact were introduced.

> The **Outstanding Research Contribution** Award recognizes PhD/MCom candidates whose work has significantly advanced knowledge and understanding in Accountancy or Finance. This award acknowledges research that has profoundly impacted the development of new theories, methodologies, or empirical analyses that have expanded the boundaries of knowledge.
>
> The **Outstanding Research Presentation** Award recognizes a PhD/MCom candidate who has given an excellent oral presentation of their research findings during the PhD symposium. This award recognizes the high quality of the research and the ability to communicate and connect with audiences, promoting knowledge sharing effectively.
>
> The **Outstanding Research Impact** Award recognizes a PhD/MCom candidate whose research findings make a significant societal, economic, environmental, or cultural impact extending beyond academia. This award acknowledges the ability to transform new knowledge into real-world benefits for communities, industries, policymaking, or other stakeholders, ultimately promoting positive change and innovation.

Previous recipients can be found in page 17.

This page has been intentionally left blank.

2026 June PhD Symposium Programme

Department of Accountancy and Finance

Otago Business School

10:25 am – 2:00 pm, Friday, 5 June 2026

OBS2.19/2.20 (Boardroom)

Organizers: Pakorn Aschakulporn and Olena Onishchenko

Welcome & Introduction, 10:25 – 10:30

→ A.Prof. Helen Roberts – Deputy Head of Department

→ Dr. Olena Onishchenko – Chair of the Postgraduate Committee

---

Presentations, 10:30 – 11:30

---

1. Xi (Tim) Xu

   Title: AI Investment and Innovation: The Role of Intellectual Property Rights

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn, A.Prof. Annie Zhang

2. Post Pokharel

   Title: Generalist CEO and Financial Reporting Quality

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, A.Prof. Syed Shams

3. Dauda (Bola) Abdulsalam

   Title: From Climate To Nature: CEO General Ability and TNFD Adoption

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi

4. Budianto

   Title: Does National Environmental Performance Matter? Evidence on Corporate Environmental Decoupling

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, Dr. Tahir Suleman, A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe

5. Md Humayun Kabir

   Title: Does CSR Committee Quality Promote Corporate Green Innovation?

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Hoa Luong, Dr. Pallab Biswas

6. Mingxuan (Steven) Yu

   Title: Predicting Short Selling Risk via Machine Learning

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Olena Onishchenko, A.Prof. Jing Zhao

7. Waleed Asghar

   Title: Climate Commitment, Climate Governance, and the Credibility of Corporate Environmental Responsibility

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Tom Stannard, Dr. Tahir Suleman

Lunch, 11:30 – 12:00

Presentations, 12:00 – 13:00

8. Yuzhe Zhang

   Title: Forecasting realized variance with option implied momentum

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

9. Minh (Brian) Le

   Title: Firm-level Nature Dependence and the Shift from Intangible to Tangible Investment

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi, A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe

10. Rui Chen

    Title: Implied Skewness as Days-to-Expiry Approaches Zero: Evidence from Option Pricing Models

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

11. Kainat Riaz

    Title: Board Deep-Level Diversity and Firm Performance

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Tom Stannard, Prof. Helen Roberts

12. Hervita Mandariani

    Title: Green Bond Issuance Outcomes - Does External Review Characteristics Matter?

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, Emeritus Prof. David Lont

13. Lachlan Williams

    Title: Values-oriented investing: Te Ao Māori Values

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, A.Prof. Katharina Ruckstuhl

14. Yufei Gan

    Title: When Financial Expertise Shapes AI Narratives: CEO Financial Background and Corporate AI Washing

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man

Awards Announcement, 13:45 – 14:00

Absences

Excused

15. Helen Sadgrove

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, A.Prof. Felicity Lamm

16. Ramez Hussein

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Iki Mafi Uele Uele, A.Prof. Nicola Beatson, Dr. Tahir Suleman

17. Tingting Wang

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, A.Prof. Annie Zhang

18. Maisam Rizvi

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi, Dr. Tahir Suleman

19. Tianjiao Li

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn, Prof. Jin Zhang

20. Muhammad Taufik

    Supervisor(s): A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe, Prof. Helen Roberts

21. Jing Zhang

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, Dr. Muhammad Cheema, Dr. Nicola Beatson

22. Thin (Paris) Pham

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, Dr. Tahir Suleman

23. Saif Choyi Valappil

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, Dr. Tahir Suleman

24. Yuliang (Leon) Zhao

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Tom Stannard, Dr. Muhammad Cheema

25. Shenjian Li

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Olena Onishchenko, A.Prof. Vitali Alexeev

26. Permata Ayu Widyasari

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, Prof. Helen Roberts

27. Huma Ali

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Tom Stannard, Dr. Tahir Suleman

28. Zhibin Tao

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, Prof. Borhan Bhuiyan

29. Yu (Anthony) Zhou

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, A.Prof. Annie Zhang

    Submitting/Submitted

30. Abdullahi Bala

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Mariela Carvajal Gallardo, Dr. Muhammad Nadeem

31. Mesfin Yasin

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man, Dr. Muhammad Cheema

32. Ruizi Hu

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

33. Yaseen Hezam

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, Prof. Tony Savarimuthu, Dr. Housam Babiker

34. Amelia Limijaya

    Supervisor(s): Emeritus Prof. Ralph Adler, Dr. Nicola Beatson

35. Abrar Hussain

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Muhammad Cheema, Prof. Borhan Bhuiyan

This page has been intentionally left blank.

Abstracts

1. Xi (Tim) Xu

   Title: AI Investment and Innovation: The Role of Intellectual Property Rights

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn, A.Prof. Annie Zhang

   Abstract:

   Using 46,572 firm-year observations of Chinese A-share firms (2007–2024), we examine how incremental AI investment affects innovation and how intellectual property rights (IPR) protection moderates this relationship. AI investment significantly improves innovation quantity and quality. However, stronger IPR protection weakens AI's positive effect on quality but not quantity, consistent with strategic patenting. This effect is concentrated in software AI investment, suggesting institutional environments shape whether AI drives genuine innovation or strategic behaviour.

2. Post Pokharel

   Title: Generalist CEO and Financial Reporting Quality

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Hoa Luong, A.Prof. Syed Shams

   Abstract:

   A growing body of literature suggests that corporations tend to prefer appointing a generalist chief executive officer (CEO) with broad industry experience over a specialist with industry-specific expertise. However, the consequences of this managerial trend for the credibility and reliability of financial reporting remain unclear. Using a large panel of US firms and multiple measures of financial reporting quality, we find that firms led by generalist CEOs exhibit significantly lower financial reporting quality, consistent with the notion that broad managerial skills are associated with greater discretion in reporting. Our results remain robust to a range of controls, alternative FRQ measures, and endogeneity-corrected estimations.

3. Dauda (Bola) Abdulsalam

   Title: From Climate To Nature: CEO General Ability and TNFD Adoption

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi

   Abstract:

   The study examines the impact of CEO's general ability and firms' TNFD-aligned disclosure. Drawing on Upper Echelons Theory and Human Capital Theory, we hypothesise that CEOs with diverse professional experiences are more likely to understand the complex and dynamic nature-related reporting requirements. We employ an unbalanced sample of non-financial S&P 1500 firms for the period 2018-2022 using a retrieval-and-scoring Natural Language Processing (NLP) methodology. We find that the CEO's general ability is positively associated with TNFD disclosure. The results remain robust across instrumental-variable estimation, propensity-score matching, and the Heckman correction. The association is stronger among firms with superior climate disclosure, highlighting the importance of CEO capability in advancing emerging environmental reporting practices.

4. Budianto

   Title: Does National Environmental Performance Matter? Evidence on Corporate Environmental Decoupling

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, Dr. Tahir Suleman, A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe

   Abstract:

   This study examines whether country-level environmental performance is associated with firm-level environmental decoupling. Using a sample of 20,312 firm-year observations across 92 countries over the period 2016–2022, we found a negative and statistically significant association between EPI and environmental decoupling, suggesting that firms located in countries with stronger environmental outcomes exhibit a smaller gap between environmental disclosure and underlying environmental performance. This finding remains robust across alternative model specifications. This study contributes to the literature by introducing country-level environmental performance as a relevant macro-level factor associated with firms' environmental decoupling.

5. Md Humayun Kabir

   Title: Does CSR Committee Quality Promote Corporate Green Innovation?

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Helen Roberts, Dr. Hoa Luong, Dr. Pallab Biswas

   Abstract:

   This study examines the impact of CSR committee quality on corporate green innovation, as assessed by green patent counts, scientific and economic value. Drawing on the pro-environmental perspective of stakeholder-agency theory, we find that higher-quality CSR committees promote green innovation. Theories of resource dependence and upper echelons complement the positive association. Further investigation of the underlying mechanism shows that the main effect is more pronounced during periods of high economic policy uncertainty, among financially constrained firms, and when CEOs possess green experience. The findings are robust to a wide range of robustness checks and tests designed to address potential endogeneity.

6. Mingxuan (Steven) Yu

   Title: Predicting Short Selling Risk via Machine Learning

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Olena Onishchenko, A.Prof. Jing Zhao

   Abstract:

   We study which firm characteristics drive the economic value of machine learning short-selling risk predictability. Three results stand out. First, profitability and liquidity are the most important factors in predicting short-selling risk. Second, machine learning methods produce more consistent short-selling risk predictability across firm-size groups, whereas traditional models are more sensitive to firm size. Third, several predictors—including value-versus-growth, the earnings-to-price ratio, and liability growth—carry negative importance. Removing these predictors improves risk-adjusted returns and helps identify characteristics that add economic value.

7. Waleed Asghar

   Title: Climate Commitment, Climate Governance, and the Credibility of Corporate Environmental Responsibility

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Tom Stannard, Dr. Tahir Suleman

   Abstract:

   Our study investigates whether corporate climate commitments and climate governance mechanisms represent credible environmental responsibility or reveal a credibility gap observable through future environmental penalties. Using a panel of U.S. listed firms, our findings show that stronger climate commitments and governance structures are positively associated with subsequent penalties, suggesting that visible climate claims and structures may coexist with unresolved environmental risks. Importantly, institutional ownership weakens these associations, suggesting that external monitoring disciplines symbolic overcommitment and improves accountability. Robustness tests using alternative measures, temporal specifications, endogeneity, and heterogeneity analyses reinforce the evidence, highlighting climate credibility as an accountability challenge rather than merely a disclosure or governance issue.

8. Yuzhe Zhang

   Title: Forecasting realized variance with option implied momentum

   Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

   Abstract:

   This paper examines whether option-implied risk-neutral moments improve realized variance forecasts and volatility-managed portfolio performance. Using HAR-based linear, machine-learning, and neural-network models on S&P 500 options data from 2007–2023, we find that short-maturity risk-neutral variance improves forecast accuracy. However, better statistical forecasts do not always produce superior economic value. Simple linear models with volatility switching deliver the strongest risk-adjusted portfolio performance and lower drawdowns.

9. Minh (Brian) Le

   Title: Firm-level Nature Dependence and the Shift from Intangible to Tangible Investment

   Supervisor(s): Dr. Duminda Kuruppuarachchi, A.Prof. Dinithi Ranasinghe

   Abstract:

   Corporate dependence on nature reshapes how firms invest. Using US non financial companies from 2013-2024, the study shows that higher reliance on ecosystem services leads firms to cut intangible investment (like R&D and brand capital) while increasing tangible investment in physical, collateral rich assets. Guided by threat rigidity theory, firms facing long term natural risks prioritize financial safety over long term innovation. Financially constrained firms shift even more aggressively toward tangible assets. Robustness checks, including 2SLS IV, entropy balancing, omitted variable tests, and quasi natural experiments, support the findings, highlighting how nature related risk drives firms toward physical adaptation with implications for investors and policymakers.

10. Rui Chen

    Title: Implied Skewness as Days-to-Expiry Approaches Zero: Evidence from Option Pricing Models

    Supervisor(s): Prof. Jin Zhang, Dr. Pakorn Aschakulporn

    Abstract:

    Motivated by the rapid growth of short-term and zero day-to-expiry (0DTE) options, this paper examines the behaviour of implied skewness as option maturity approaches zero. The analysis compares Black-Scholes (BS), Merton jump-diffusion, Heston stochastic volatility, Bates stochastic volatility with jumps, and the local-in-time Edgeworth 0DTE pricing framework of Bandi, Fusari, and Renò (JF, forthcoming). These models differ in how they generate skewness through asymmetric jumps, stochastic volatility, leverage effects, and local-in-time skewness adjustments. This paper examines whether near-expiration skewness differs across pricing models and helps clarify how model choice affects the interpretation of implied skewness in the 0DTE option market.

11. Kainat Riaz

    Title: Board Deep-Level Diversity and Firm Performance

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Tom Stannard, Prof. Helen Roberts

    Abstract:

    This study examines how boardroom diversity influences firms' financial performance by moving beyond surface-level demographic factors. It provides a novel approach by operationalising those variables that explicitly highlight deep-level diversity of a boardroom, such as social capital, symbolic capital, financial expertise, recognition, and educational background. Using firm-level panel data, this study will empirically examine the impact of deep-level board diversity on a firm's performance. By shifting the focus from directors' demographics to how they think, behave, and connect, this research offers a more detailed analysis and framework for evaluating how a board's composition adds value to a firm's financial performance.

12. Hervita Mandariani

    Title: Green Bond Issuance Outcomes – Does External Review Characteristics Matter?

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, Emeritus Prof. David Lont

    Abstract:

    This study examines whether second-party opinions (SPOs) enhance the credibility and environmental effectiveness of green bond issuances. Unlike previous studies that often treat external review as a dummy variable, it evaluates the specific attributes and information contained in SPOs. Using data from Bloomberg and LSEG, we construct a firm-level panel of first-time green bond issuers between 2013 and 2024. The sample covers 928 green bonds first issuers with 288 distinct issuers. A Difference-in-Differences design is employed to test whether SPO characteristics predict subsequent reductions in issuers' emissions intensity following initial green bond issuance.

13. Lachlan Williams

    Title: Values-oriented investing: Te Ao Māori Values

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Sebastian Gehricke, A.Prof. Katharina Ruckstuhl

    Abstract:

    Values-oriented investing has become increasingly mainstream, yet the alignment of investment portfolios with the cultural values of Indigenous entities remains underexplored. This study addresses this gap by investigating how Māori Asset Holding Organizations (MAHI) define, measure, and integrate their values into their investment processes. Utilizing a multi-method framework, the study involves semi-structured interviews and comprehensive policy document analysis to identify investment values. Combined with a quantitative portfolio analysis of listed equities to assess how effectively these values are delivered by external fund managers compared to internal strategies. Overall, this research contributes to the emerging field of Indigenous Sustainable Finance (ISF).

14. Yufei Gan

    Title: When Financial Expertise Shapes AI Narratives: CEO Financial Background and Corporate AI Washing

    Supervisor(s): Dr. Yimei Man

    Abstract:

    Drawing on upper echelons theory, this study examines whether CEOs' financial backgrounds contribute to corporate AI washing in an emerging-market context. Using Chinese A-share listed firms from 2010 to 2023, we find that CEOs with financial backgrounds significantly increase firms' engagement in corporate AI washing. This finding remains robust to alternative measures, sample restrictions, propensity score matching, instrumental-variable estimation, and placebo tests. Channel analyses suggest that financially experienced CEOs intensify AI washing by increasing short-term financial asset allocation and reducing R&D investment. The effect is more pronounced when external verification is weaker and capital-market pressure is stronger.

This page has been intentionally left blank.

Previous Award Recipients

	Outstanding Research		
	Contribution	Presentation	Impact
2026S1			
2025S2	Humayun Kabir	Permata Ayu Widyasari	Tan (Alex) Do
2025S1	Post Pokharel	Thin (Paris) Pham	Muhammad Taufik
2024S2	Weihan Li	Jing Zhang	Amelia Limijaya
2024S1	Arung Mayapada	Duminda Karunarathne	Andre Poyser